

Harish Hande

Dr. Harish Hande (born 1967) co-founded SELCO India in 1995 and later established SELCO Foundation in 2010, pioneering decentralised renewable energy solutions that link sustainable energy with poverty eradication. His work has democratised access to energy, healthcare, livelihoods and education for India's underserved rural and urban poor communities

Education

- Bachelor of Technology in Energy Engineering, Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Kharagpur, India (1990).
- Master's degree in Renewable Energy Engineering, University of Massachusetts Lowell, USA (1998).
- PhD in Mechanical Engineering (concentration in Energy), University of Massachusetts Lowell, USA (2000).

Career

Harish's journey began during his doctoral fieldwork in Sri Lanka and the Dominican Republic, where he witnessed firsthand how simple solar energy solutions transformed the lives of communities living in deep poverty. Inspired by this, he returned to India in 1994 and, with co-founder Neville Williams, established the Solar Electric Light Company (SELCO India) in 1995 in Bengaluru with an initial capital of just Rs. 15,000. SELCO India challenged three prevailing assumptions: that the poor cannot afford clean energy, cannot maintain it, and that a commercial enterprise cannot pursue social objectives. Harish himself installed the first 1,000 home lighting systems.

Over the next two decades, SELCO India installed solar systems in over 500,000 households across Karnataka, Kerala and beyond. In 2010, recognising that the learnings from SELCO India could be amplified, Harish founded SELCO Foundation as an open-source innovation lab to link sustainable energy with poverty alleviation. He stepped back from SELCO India's active management in 2014 to focus on the Foundation as its CEO. He has since served on India's Ministry of New and Renewable Energy solar committee and advised global bodies including the WHO and IRENA on decentralised energy and climate action.

Awards and Recognition

- Ramon Magsaysay Award, 2011 — Asia's highest civilian honour, often called "Asia's Nobel Prize"
- Skoll Award for Social Entrepreneurship, 2018.
- Social Entrepreneur of the Year, 2007 — Schwab Foundation & Nand and Jeet Khemka Foundation



Leadership at SELCO

As Founder and CEO of SELCO Foundation, Harish leads an ecosystem-building organisation that uses sustainable energy as a catalyst to democratise health, education and livelihoods for the poor. Under his leadership, SELCO has solar-powered over 1,300 public health facilities across Karnataka, Odisha, Meghalaya, Nagaland and Manipur — benefitting more than 7 million people — and is on track, with the IKEA Foundation and the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, to power 25,000 health centres across India by 2026–27. The Foundation has improved livelihoods for over 900,000 people through solar-powered sewing machines, millet processing units, cold storage and irrigation pumps; developed 120+ replicable Decentralised Renewable Energy (DRE) solutions; and unlocked financing for 10,000+ micro-entrepreneurs via partnerships with regional rural banks, MFIs and cooperatives. Through the Sustainable Energy-led Climate Action Programme (SELCAP), Harish has positioned SELCO at the intersection of climate action and economic justice, with global replication work underway in the Philippines, Tanzania and other parts of the Global South.

Harish's Talk and Articles

- [Solar Man of India | Ft. Harish Hande | SELCO | Exploring Minds](#)
- [Dr Harish Hande - On Empathy, Energy and the Last Mile](#)
- [Dignity in Watts: The SELCO Way to Rural Prosperity with Harish Hande](#)